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OnePlus Nord Buds

Go for it – with caution

OnePlus has launched the OnePlus Nord Buds, making it the company's first budget true wireless earphones. However, there has been increasing competition in the budget TWS market, with players like Realme and Oppo bringing their A-game to the table with every launch. So, to test where the OnePlus Nord Buds stand, we put these TWS earphones through their paces in our testing process. Here's what we found out.

BUILD, DESIGN, AND FIT

The OnePlus Nord Buds hold their ground when it comes to build quality. The outer case, which is made of glossy plastic, despite being prone to picking up scratches over time, does give the product a premium feel. OnePlus's attention to detail with the seams and the overall fit of the buds make the purchase feel worth it. Fingerprints were not a noticeable issue in our white review unit. Due to its boxy design, the case is not particularly easy to fit in the pocket. The earbuds are light and feature a boxy stem that tends not to protrude out of the ear. The weight of the earbuds also makes wearing them for longer periods easy. Two silver concave touch-sensitive buttons add tasteful bling to the rather mute buds' design.

FEATURES

One should not hold high expectations at the price at which the OnePlus Nord Buds slot in. There is no ANC, the range is decent, and there is no wireless charging. These are the features one shouldn't expect in this price range. When we got to our testing, though, all the remaining scoring slots took no time to be populated with what we can call decent numbers.

They come with an IP55 rating, which makes them fit to be worn during workout sessions. The controls are intuitive and responsive. The concave



shape of the touch-sensitive area on the buds makes it very easy to locate the touch points. Controls can be modified to trigger various actions in the settings menu in select devices, while other users will have to download the HeyMelody app. The battery level indicator in the app is a nice addition too.

PERFORMANCE

On the spec sheet, things look impressive. They come equipped with 12.4 mm Titanium drivers that support Dolby Atmos. But the actual performance was underwhelming.

We had set out with high expectations when we decided to play Hotel California on these earphones. It was not long before, though, that we were brought back to the reality that these are a budget pair of earphones. The sound we got was laden with bass, with the highs and the mids missing the punch that one would expect a driver of the size in this pair should have. As we played different tracks, one thing was apparent these are meant for the bass heads. For anyone apart from this section that would love the OnePlus Nord Buds, the listening experience would be pretty underwhelming. In our testing process, they came out behind their direct competitors on the market, the Realme Buds 3. Moving on to the performance of the microphone. This is where OnePlus Nord Buds redeemed themselves. The sound, although

muddy at times, was clear and even in the most challenging situations, the buds held their ground well. Ambient sounds were suppressed well during calls. Again, not to forget, this is when compared to other similarly priced devices. So, tune your expectations accordingly. OnePlus markets support for Dolby Atmos with the Nord Buds. However, it is limited to certain high-end devices and could not be found working with the Nord CE2 that we used during our testing.



BUILD	69
FEATURES	66
PERFORMANCE	72
VALUE	84

BATTERY LIFE

The OnePlus Nord Buds played music for six and a half hours straight during our testing, with the volume set to around 50 per cent. The case promises to provide another four full charges to the earbuds,

which would push the overall battery life to around 30 hours. The lack of ANC and transparency modes helps the OnePlus Nord Buds match the numbers mentioned on the spec sheets. With the additional Flash Charge capability baked in, as advertised, you can get 5 hours of playback with just 10 minutes of charging.

VERDICT

At ₹2,799, the OnePlus Nord Buds are a good recommendation for anyone looking to buy a reliable pair of TWS earphones in the sub 3k price range. The sound quality is decent and the best available for bass heads. You should look elsewhere though, if you are looking for a well-balanced sound. To sum it up in a single sentence—Budget package, that punches well within its weight.

—Sativik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

FREQUENCY RESPONSE: 20 Hz - 20,000 Hz | DRIVER: 12.4 mm dynamic titanium | BATTERY LIFE (EARBUDS): 7 hours | BATTERY LIFE (CASE): 30 hours | FLASH CHARGING: 10 minutes of charge gives 5 hours of battery life | IP RATING: IP55 | WEIGHT (EARBUDS): 4.82 g | Bluetooth Audio Codecs: SBC, AAC

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